on cash deposits at RBI counters post 30 December were all part of a strategy attempting to try and slow down the avalanche of cash that was coming in to the banks.

Further, given the complete absence of data on notes returned after 12 December 2016 and the refusal to respond to RTI queries, many surmised that the RBI's uncharacteristic silence was a consequence of the pressure it was under to 'show' the right numbers.

Fall from Grace

Demonetization extracted a heavy price from banks and bankers.

Bank staff across the country worked punishingly long hours. All regular banking activity came to a stand-still – opening a new bank account or getting a loan became impossible. Bankers simply had no time for customers as they struggled to count old notes and to disburse new notes, while complying with the RBI's frequently changing notifications.

The note ban took a heavy toll on their health. Some literally paid with their lives.[54] S.K. Sheriff, 46-year-old Deputy Manager, SBI, Andhra Pradesh, collapsed working 14 hours a day and died in the hospital. Prem Shankar Prajapati, 33-year-old cashier from Gujarat, committed suicide due to stress. R.V. Rajesh, aged 51, a bank employee in Maharashtra, had a heart attack and died. Noel Topno, aged 52 years, Chief Manager, Central Bank of India, West Bengal, died of a cardiac arrest while working.

While the vast majority of bank staff were doing their best, there were, sadly, a few rotten apples. As India stood in queues and struggled to get a few new notes, some people mysteriously managed to obtain fat bundles of brand new ₹2,000 and ₹500 notes.

Armed with mobile camera phones, citizen journalists started sharing videos on social media of certain bank managers surreptitiously handing wads of notes to VIP clients through back